

Kickoff — Forming the Company

How to run the first meeting — what happens, how to run it, and why it matters.

THE ONE GOAL

By the end: a company with six owners, a safety ritual that runs on its own, and an open outreach log. The goal is not a robot — it is a team that exists.

HOW THIS CLASS IS TAUGHT — YOU LEAD, THE KIDS OWN

The kickoff is advisor-led (the deck is parent-facing teaching material, which Section 4.3 allows). Your job is to **facilitate** — especially the role conversation, which the kids decide, not you. MATE's own *Company Formation* activity mirrors this meeting, so there is nothing to change — the optional [How to Get a Team Started](#) is good advisor background.

BEFORE YOU TEACH THIS

- **Read the season plan and the Phase 1 plan** so you can answer “where is this going?” with confidence.
- **Prepare the six role descriptions** — a printed card per role so kids can sit with all six.
- **Place the long-lead orders** (see the Prep Sheet) — battery, SeaMATE kits, and soldering stations all have lead time.
- **Set up the safety-brief card** — the four standing questions — and run the first brief yourself.
- **Recommended reading:** *Underwater Robotics* intro (Ch 1 §1.1–1.3; Ch 2 §2.1–2.2) for the “what is an ROV” background.
- **Section 4.3:** facilitate the role choice — never assign the roles.

WHY THIS CLASS MATTERS

MATE asks teams to run like a real engineering company, not a class — “you will not have a teacher running this; you will have a boss, and the boss is each other.” Everything the season needs — ownership, a safety habit, an honest record of outreach — is installed here, in the first room, before a single part is bought. Get the company formed and the rituals running, and the rest of Phase 1 has something to build on. Skip it, and you spend the season chasing accountability.

THE SIX ROLES — EVERY STUDENT OWNS ONE

ROLE	OWNS
CEO — Chief Executive	The schedule, the meeting agenda, and the health of every sub-team.
CFO — Chief Financial	The budget and every purchase; tracks spend against what was raised.
Mechanical Lead	The frame, the float body, and the manipulator — everything that moves or holds.
Electrical Lead	The tether, the control box, and every connection that carries current.
Software Lead	The control code and the computer-vision work that reads the camera.
Communications Lead	The project notebook, the outreach log, and the team's marketing story.

Roles can rotate at phase boundaries; no role is lesser than another.

HOW THE MEETING RUNS — BLOCK BY BLOCK

0:00 • 15 MIN **Welcome & safety brief**

Open with the very first safety brief and name it as the standing ritual: walk the four questions — what are we doing, what could hurt someone, how do we prevent it, who do we tell — and tell the team every meeting will open exactly here. The habit has to exist before there's any danger in the room, so you install it on day one.

0:15 • 30 MIN **What we're joining**

Orient the team: what MATE is, what the RANGER class actually asks for, and where the season ends. Name the five deliverables — an ROV, a profiling float, technical documentation, a live no-slides presentation, and a marketing display — and point to Dauphin Island in late April. Before they build anything, the team should know exactly what it signed up for.

0:45 • 45 MIN **We are a company — the heart of the day**

This block decides how the team works all season, so give it room. The kids hear all six roles, write a first and second choice, talk it through, and you confirm the final set — you facilitate, they decide; never assign a seat. A seat chosen is a seat owned, and roles can rotate at phase boundaries, so no choice is a cage.

1:40 • 35 MIN **The season ahead**

Walk the six phases from June to April quickly, then land on Phase 1: by July, a team that exists, a starter ROV in the water, and kids who have soldered. Everyone should be able to see how today's meeting connects to the regional ten months out.

2:15 • 20 MIN **Building our safety culture**

Move from the brief to the habits that live between briefs — the five everyday ones: tool discipline, clear floors, closed-toe shoes, reporting small problems, and looking out for each other. Hand the brief to the CEO from here on. A brief is a moment; a culture is the habit, and the habit is what keeps kids safe.

2:35 • 15 MIN **The community outreach log**

Open the outreach log live, with this meeting as entry one — the Communications Lead owns it, four columns, nothing fancy: date, what we did, who it reached, reach count. Outreach is scored and impossible to reconstruct in April, so the rule is simple: if it happened, it gets logged the same week.

2:50 · 10 MIN Wrap-up & homework

Close the loop and set the bridge to Class 1.2. Homework: know your role, watch the MATE pre-watch for 1.2 (*Using Tools, Soldering & Waterproofing Wires*), and bring closed-toe shoes. On the adult track, confirm the meeting slot and transport and place the long-lead orders. The flipped model starts now — concepts pre-watched so 1.2 goes straight to the bench.

MATE RESOURCES FOR THIS CLASS

Supplemental / follow-up homework after kickoff. Source: the [TriggerFish ROV Guide](#).

- [ROV 101 and ROV Design](#) (what an ROV is) HOMework
- [Company Formation](#) (mirrors this class) ACTIVITY
- [How to Get a Team Started](#) INSTRUCTOR

WHAT “DONE” LOOKS LIKE

Six roles owned and each kid can name what theirs owns. The safety ritual is installed and the CEO can run it. The outreach log is open with entry one written. That is the whole gate — and it is enough.